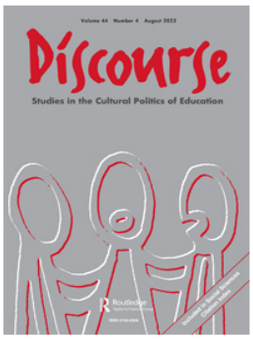

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Disenchantment revisited: school life in Northwest China

Liqin Tong and Yisu Zhou

Faculty of Education, University of Macau, Taipa, Macao

ABSTRACT
Typically understood through a universal-statist framework, modern schooling in contemporary China often contributes to the disenchantment of ethnic students. Based on year-long research in a Tibetan-serving secondary school, we provide additional insight in this discussion. We argue that to treat disenchantment as a fixed state ignores the space-temporal quality of human action. The school's social process is multiple and momentary in nature and often undermines the seemingly linear educational programming. Under the rigid school setting emerge social spaces that expand beyond academic lessons. In those spaces, students continue to interact among themselves and with teachers, where withdrawal and marginalization happen alongside negotiation, appropriation, and participation. While disenchantment anchors the classroom experience of many, it interpenetrates and enmeshes with other aspects of student lives and is interwoven over time. By considering this complex interplay of disenchantment we upend the notion of disenchantment as a singular state, and illustrate this idea through two examples.

KEYWORDS
Disenchantment; processualism; social space; Tibetan students; school relocation; institutionalism

Introduction

Educational discourse in today's China is at a strange crossroads. On the one hand, the 'high-performing state' narrative portrays a picture of progressing teaching and learning to both domestic and international audiences (Tan, 2013). On the other hand, stirred desire and anxiety drag millions of parents and children into a spiral arms race for achievement and upward social mobility (Kipnis, 2011). Yet, for the many students who are not caught in such a craze, there are other lingering issues inside schooling. When the contemporary Chinese school system achieved what education historians called 'social efficiency' (Labaree, 1997), it also engendered disenchantment in rural, migrant, and ethnic minority students.

The current literature shows that there is a gap in educational achievement between rural/ethnic minority students and students from the dominant culture (Hannum, 2002, 2003; Makarova & Birman, 2015). High dropout rates, lack of educational infrastructure, low household socioeconomic status (SES), poor academic attainment, and passive withdrawal inside classrooms are common among these groups (Hannum, 2000; Lu et al., 2016). Despite the educational policies issued by many countries that have been

CONTACT Liqin Tong yb87104@um.edu.mo
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committed to providing them with convenient resources, schooling for these groups produces only mixed results (Postiglione, 2008; Wu, 2012). Undoubtedly, as Buchmann and Hannum (2001) concluded, macro-structural forces, family backgrounds, and school-based determinants affect educational stratification in developing countries. Apart from these reasons, previous studies argued that rural/ethnic minority students' disillusionment was also attributable to residential/geographical disadvantages (Hannum, 2002), dim job prospects (Bangsbo, 2008), language barriers (Beckett & Postiglione, 2012), culturally irrelevant curriculum (Postiglione & Jiao, 2009), and disillusioned ethnic belonging (Yang, 2017), etc.

Disenchantment is a central crux faced by the developmental state. Constructed under the modernization framework, schooling is often treated as an instrument for linear social progress. It is anchored on the contested triumphalism that literacy and numeracy pave the foundation of human capital formation and economic development. Yet, for many of those mentioned above, such an ideology remains disconnected from their daily lives. In many cases, it contradicts their epistemic practices and beliefs altogether (Wu, 2012; Zhu, 2007).

Like many modern ideologies, the education program envisioned by the developmental state is riddled with contradictions. Nevertheless, on its rigid terrain, there roam many different local currents. The school setting often deceives the observer into treating the education system as a fixed environment, despite the presence of constant changes. In this particular case, we examined a school relocation project for a Tibetan-serving community. It resembles many issues embodied by contemporary Chinese schooling just described: most students are from pastoral herdsman families, they have a low level of parental involvement in a boarding environment, and they have a low level of academic performance. However, spending time in this school also made us realize that the classroom experience should be contextualized within the school's larger social setting.

Schooling, for the most part, is not a fixed-point event but has a spatial–temporal quality.[1] In our case, students spent three to six years in a community with peers and teachers, where disenchantment, be it at the initial or later stage of studying, often was evident. But at the same time, disenchantment intersected with other aspects of social life. Simply put, the schooling experience extends beyond academic learning and involves a significant amount of leisure time, sports, and extracurricular activities.

Literature on China's ethnic minority education has mainly focused on relocation policy (Leibold, 2019; Yang, 2019), bilingual education (Beckett & Postiglione, 2012; Zhang & Tsung, 2019), or minority students' ethnic belonging (Xu & Yang, 2019). To our knowledge, previous studies have paid limited attention to considering what exactly students' lives are like at such an institution. Using an ethnographic approach, we focused more on the flow of these students' daily lives. The questions that perplexed us and remain critically underexplored are: What kind of school-based incentives or activities engaged Tibetan students when they were not attuned to academic learning? How did they spend/experience their school life (or present themselves) in a learning environment dominated by cultures alien to their upbringing? By viewing school life as an integrated social space, we find surprising levels of local appropriation, negotiation, and participation.

The spatial–temporal quality of schooling compels the questions of whether disenchantment is a state of mind, a period of status, or an enduring character. What eventually

became of the disenchanted students? The disenchantment argument leads us to think critically about the purpose and practices of education. However, the argument also ignores the most important element of social process: the conflating of the fixed-point view of the social process with a processual view.[2] Students eventually became young adults and moved on with their lives. When the present disenchantment is encoded into their lived experiences, it permeates and interpenetrates other social lineages such as ethnic identity, religion, and popular youth culture. Therefore, by studying the conditioning forces that surrounded disenchanted students, we seek to provide new insights into educational policy research, as well as connect with the literature of social process. By contextualizing a group of Tibetan students, we show that disenchantment could catalyze change and negotiation and is contingent upon a conjuncture of large and small forces.

Ethnographic context

The empirical data presented here derives from the 12 months of ethnographic research conducted between 2019 and 2020 by the first author and interviews by both authors. We collected the data in an ethnic minority secondary school in a city of Qinghai province in China. This school is set up for Tibetan students from the Three-River Headwater (TRH) region in western China, which has been known for its harsh climate and poor living conditions. Today, more than 90% of the existing Tibetan population in the TRH region are herders.

Due to climate change and human activities, the ecosystem of the TRH region has gradually deteriorated, threatening not only the ecological security but also the livelihoods of local nomads and regional socioeconomic development (Yan, Li, Hua, Peng, & Zhang, 2017). To alleviate the situation, the state and local governments have implemented various measures, including compensating Tibetan nomads for migrating out of the TRH region to urban and semi-urban settlement towns. This project is referred to as the 'Ecological Migration Project' (EMP), which started in 2006 and called for the relocation of more than 55,000 Tibetan pastoralists (Du, 2012). Parallel to the EMP, a series of educational programs were also implemented in the TRH region to improve the quality of local education, optimize the allocation of rural education resources, and expand access to compulsory education.

The focus of the present study is the program type 'Relocated Education' (*yidijiaoyu,* RE for short). RE set up centralized teaching facilities *within* Qinghai, aiming to offset issues with other types of educational programs for the Tibetan students, such as *neidiban.*[3] RE in Qinghai aims to serve more Tibetan students sans *neidiban*'s restrictions of school scale, class size, the number of students, and geographical location. Those sites for RE are in towns/cities with better educational resources, and are generally economically developed areas in Qinghai. The program is free but also requires the students to board at school.

The site of our research is a minority secondary boarding school, the TsuGur minority secondary school (*pseudonym*). This school is one of the local products under the influence of the aforementioned policy. TsuGur is 800 kilometers away from the TRH region. It is in a multi-ethnic city with a population of over one million on the Qinghai-Tibet Plateau. Educational officials claim that the Tibetan children from the TRH region will be able to access high-quality educational resources in such urban and modern settings. TsuGur is a full-time boarding school that is walled off from the outside. It combines

the lower secondary section (grades 7–9) and the upper secondary section (grades 10–12). At present, it houses about 3,600 students, and almost 96% of the students are Tibetan with over 90% coming from low-income nomadic families. Many of the parents have a low educational attainment level and their families make a living by grazing or working outside as migrant workers. TsuGur is generously supported by the provincial government. All the teachers have at least a bachelor's degree, which is uncommon in schools of this region. The school boasts state-of-the-art facilities, far surpassing other secondary schools in Qinghai.

Methods and data

We conducted a pilot study in several ethnic minority schools in Qinghai province in 2018 to ascertain the feasibility of the following proposed larger study. After careful selection, we chose TsuGur as our field site because we wanted to understand a contemporary, Tibetan-serving school. TsuGur serves a large Tibetan student body, but its orientation reflects other Chinese high schools: academically oriented, tightly regularized, and a highly professional Han-majority teaching force. The interview protocols were developed during the pilot study based on the first few visits to TsuGur. We constantly modified them during the research process. It was apparent from our observations that the students were not interested in the academically oriented classes. Gradually, this project revolved around explaining why the disinterest happened. The rest of the study was built on top of this puzzle.

We combined participant observation with interviews (unstructured and semi-structured) in daily field activities. The observations include classroom observation, students' lives in the boarding institution, teacher-student daily interaction, and school activities. We conducted open-ended interviews with teachers, students, school principals and staff, and parents/guardians, while informal conversations and discussions were also conducted with these participants. Thirty lower-secondary students, 26 upper-secondary students, 22 teachers, 2 principals, 12 school staff, and 17 parents/guardians were interviewed in total. Focus group discussions were also carried out among students (each group with 4–6 individuals) to understand their school life and social interaction issues. Among them, 32 students were interviewed twice because they participated in both open-ended interviews and group discussions.

This study is a typical 'school ethnography' (Ogbu, 1981). All interviews were conducted in the school field during participants' leisure time without concentrating on a certain period. For example, interviews with our participants were conducted when they had no classes or work during the school day. Interviews with parents/guardians took place mainly through daily talks when they were waiting outside the schools to pick up their children. Questions were mainly asked about their personal/family background, their experiences of education, and their expectations for the future, etc.

The first author has served as a temporary librarian and a volunteer teacher in TsuGur under the arrangement of the vice-principal, which allowed us to gain access to diverse educational and entertainment activities in school. The year-long fieldwork was mainly carried out by the first author, who participated in every process of research and writing. The second author contributed to the interviews, the conceptualization, and the writing of the current paper. The first author was able to take part fully in every

aspect of school life, including meals with teachers and students, sports and arts activities, assisting school administrators with student affairs. These experiences afforded the authors with a more nuanced image of school lives.

The analysis also draws on oral history, archives, policy, and institutional documents. All text-based materials were organized by the qualitative data analysis software NVivo 12 for coding, thereby identifying themes and the relationship between categories (Saldaña, 2016). We followed the procedures of 'flexible coding' proposed by Deterding and Waters (2018) as we believe this analytic method can better increase transparency, reliability, and validity. We followed the steps of indexing the transcripts, identifying the main 'stories', data reduction, examining the analytic coding, and testing the data-based theory. Furthermore, to improve the reliability and validity of our interpretations, we worked together to code the data to cross-check whether any important topics had been ignored and to test the strength of our interpretations. As argued by Jerolmack and Khan (2014), self-reporting is often of limited value in predicting what people actually do. Therefore, we triangulated the one-to-one interview data with other sources of data before making inferences. Finally, we presented the transcripts to the informants to compare their interpretations of the data with ours.

Disenchantment in TsuGur

School days at TsuGur adhered to the following daily routine: students wake up at 6:30 and have breakfast, followed by their morning reading classes at 7:30. Students then attend the rest of their courses (9 classes a day, 40 min each), from 8:00 to 17:30, which includes a lunch break from 12:30 to 14:00. After dinner, students engage in a self-study session from 18:30 to 21:30. During this time, the school requires students to complete their homework quietly or attend occasional review sessions held by their teachers. Of course, not every activity is academic, and students have leisure time in between classes.

Our research question stems from an empirical puzzle. It was apparent from our first visit that the students at TsuGur were not interested in the academically oriented classes. Class after class, they looked listless and droopy. Many seemed absent-minded, often with a puzzled look on their faces. Quite a number of students dozed off during teaching sessions. When being called to answer questions, they were nervous. According to the interviews, a lot of Tibetan students admitted that they struggled with learning. School administrators relayed to us that students did very poorly on standardized tests. Despite the fact that Tibetan students are given a much simpler college matriculation exam rather than the National College Entrance Examination (*gaokao)*, only a quarter of the high school graduating cohort entered college in 2019. These Tibetan students are clearly maladjusted to the most salient educational ethos of today's China: academic-oriented learning. This predicament can be explained on two levels, corresponding to the students' situation 'before relocation' and 'after relocation'.

At the *practical level*, modern academic learning implies incremental effort, which requires the learner to consolidate prior knowledge and practice regularly. But these elements are absent at the elementary level for the students we met. Before relocation, they lived in the sparsely populated pasture with an exceptionally long commute to and from school. Often, the elementary schools house multiple grades and lack well-

trained teachers. The harsh living environment and economic stagnation have further limited the availability of educational resources in the region. Although students were promoted successively, few of them developed any real academic foundation.

More than half of the students in TsuGur come from single-parent families or are orphans. Most Tibetan parents/guardians are illiterate herders, and they rarely get involved in schooling. According to the participants, Tibetan parents usually show less motivation and strength in school participation owing to the lack of institutional knowledge, time, energy, and money. Also, they seldom have 'guanxi' (Xie & Postiglione, 2016), a term referred to as social networks that serve as an asset in modern society, to improve their children's chances of school success. This initial status quo led to frustration in students' academic learning. In other words, the long-standing educational issues in Tibetan pastoral areas led to the formation of a matrix of obstinate learning patterns or habitus before these students came to TsuGur.

Students were met with additional challenges at *the cultural level* once they came to TsuGur. Here, the disenchantment at *the cultural level* can be explained according to three aspects. First, TsuGur uses Chinese as the medium of instruction (CMI).[4] In China, CMI is called the 'L2' language policy, as the state has stressed a unified language, which is believed to be crucial for national unity and social development (Zhang & Tsung, 2019). The only exception is the Tibetan language class for these students. The CMI policy created a massive barrier for the students whose mother tongue is Tibetan or one of the other dialects in the region. It also created a strong sense of failure. Damba Gyatso, the vice-principal, told us:

> Most of the Tibetan students in our school are not prepared linguistically or culturally for the new school system and educational style … Especially for the newcomers, they have great difficulties in understanding Chinese … Gradually, many of them would lose interest (in learning), lag behind, and even develop weariness toward the school.

Second, the irrelevance of the nationally standardized curriculum to Tibetan culture makes teaching and learning an arduous effort. The content of the school curriculum in China often reflects mainstream priorities. Through schooling, students are expected to embrace the state's political and cultural propositions. Previous studies have indicated that ethnic minority students can hardly achieve their potential without culturally responsive education (Gay, 2002; Reyes-Aceytuno, 2020). The unified curriculum has attracted criticism in the past. It is divorced from the culture of ethnically diverse students while setting unrealistic high standards for those same students (Postiglione, 2009; Postiglione & Jiao, 2009).

TsuGur is no exception in this regard. The school's main subjects simply followed the standard educational content, unified textbooks, and mainstream curriculum design used in urban schools without accounting for the Tibetan culture, history, and literature. Although TsuGur offers Tibetan language classes for students, the teaching content is strictly controlled. Many students have expressed their disinclination toward the uninteresting and difficult curriculum as it is not culturally relevant for them and because it was difficult for them to actively express their ideas in class.

Finally, apart from the aforementioned two teaching aspects at *the cultural level*, Tibetan students' value systems also diverged from the school's learning culture. In terms of epistemology, students who grew up in pastoral areas spend their days

helping families graze or do chores at home. In religious-centered communities, students' daily lives revolve around spinning the prayer wheels, participating in rituals, following their parents to pilgrimage, and worshiping holy mountains and lakes. To be educated in the traditional sense, one is expected to build noble character and to develop an intimate relationship with the land. It is about sensing the human links in a great chain of being that includes animals, plants, and inanimate things; about holding a holistic view of the world and understanding more than one way of 'knowing'. Thus, to be educated in Buddhist culture has a spiritual trajectory: the learner seeks intrinsic enlightenment beyond the linguistic coding of cosmic order, a path inward (Pittman, 2001, p. 197). Such an emphasis on the virtues of memorization, spirituality, and moral-ethnic standards, as Kipnis (2011, p. 136) described, are not unique but common characteristics in almost all agricultural or religious societies.

Unlike the modern concept of learning, the education of Tibetan students primarily takes place in the fields, by the rivers, and around the sheepcotes. In such a pedagogical pattern, the natural propensity of knowing is the dominant mode of learning, in which literacy is not merely linguistic. According to the interviews, academic achievement is less important for many of TsuGur's Tibetan teachers, parents, and students than developing good morality. Thus, it is not surprising that students of TsuGur have not taken academic learning seriously. These epistemic dissonances disengage them from academic pursuits.

To summarize, the disenchantment faced by Tibetan students results from multiple forces. As an institution, TsuGur embodied many issues faced by contemporary Tibetan students despite the best policy efforts. Schooling placed these students at a conjuncture between modernized discourse and Tibetan culture, between nomadic life and urban life. Their relocation created a rift between their new experiences and their previous nomadic life, learning experiences, traditional family life, and religious living experiences. Thus, it is not hard to see why these adolescents did not respond as intended to academic-oriented learning.

Social spaces inside TsuGur

If the students are constantly disenchanted with their school lives, why is there no open revolt in TsuGur? During our time inside the school, we observed passive withdrawal inside the classroom, but the scene outside of it was quite different. Students could not wait to run to the playground as soon as the class recess bell rang; their faces were drenched with sweat when they rushed back to the classroom after merely 10-minute breaks; they fought and chased one another around the school buildings; their piercing laughter and screams filled the corridor.

At first sight, we dismissed this 'free time' as a mere interlude in a highly regimented school schedule, but the more time we spent in the school, the more our views shifted: the Newtonian time did not reflect the experienced time (Abbott, 2016, p. 191). As psychologist colleagues would have explained to us, in such a flow state, 'hours pass by in minutes, and minutes can stretch out to seem like hours' (Csikszentmihalyi, 1990, p. 49). We observe students engaging in social moments with focus, passion, and enjoyment. In TsuGur, students did—consciously or unconsciously—explore other channels to create a new social space. They took advantage of the officially designated 'free time' to

engage in sports and musical activities. They also appropriated school tasks such as putting up routine blackboard newspapers. Much of the previous research overlooks the concurrent and momentary nature of schools' social processes. To understand the changing nature of schooling, we use the ecological/processual approach. In this approach, schooling, like any social structure, is viewed as being in constant flux. Under the seemingly rigid school setting, there roam many different local currents which constantly make and remake social actors (Abbott, 2016, p. 202). We argue that such moments of making and remaking show the personal agency of the students. We illustrate this point using two instances.

Blackboard newspaper

The first instance of personal agency we noticed was that during class intermissions, during lunch and dinner break, or even during evening self-study sessions, students were working on something at the back blackboard of the classrooms.

Blackboard newspaper (*heiban bao*) is a common element in Chinese schools. Its history can be traced back a hundred years. At that time, in order to encourage the masses to participate in revolutionary activities, the blackboard newspaper became a crucial propaganda medium of grassroots organizations, undertaking the mission of publicizing state ideology and educating the people (Tian, 2011). Until now, the implicit educational function of blackboard newspapers was widely utilized by the state, schools, and teachers. As expected, most of the topics of the blackboard newspaper in TsuGur were moral principles that revolved around China's state ideology, such as civility, persistence, patriotism, and integrity. The theme of the blackboard newspaper was strictly set by the school.

In TsuGur, students of each class are divided into several groups, and all of them can take part in the blackboard newspaper's production. There are routine (weekly or biweekly issues) and special versions (nonregular events and occasions) of the newspaper. A group of several students brainstormed the particular designs. Normally, the typographic design of the blackboard newspaper in TsuGur is composed of two parts: one side includes a few Chinese sentences related to the theme, while the other side is the parallel contents in Tibetan (see Figure 1 below). In the residual space, students draw pictures to decorate the blackboard and to make it esthetically pleasing. The students present the proposed design to the headteacher for approval. After that, the students commence with the actual drawing and writing. A jury composed of school teachers then assesses each class's blackboard newspaper and rates them.

The blackboard newspaper is becoming increasingly marginalized and routine in many Chinese schools. However, during our fieldwork in TsuGur, unexpectedly, the blackboard newspaper was repeatedly mentioned by students. The creation and publishing of the blackboard newspaper were taken over by the students. For them, creating a blackboard newspaper mixes fun and self-awareness. The blackboard newspaper offered them an outlet to perform their spirituality, ethnicity, and emotion in this relocated environment. As students explained, they rarely have access to the outside modern world or use mobile devices as per the school rules. Blackboard newspapers, naturally, became one of the few outlets for collective emotional expression. Whenever

Figure 1. The layout of the blackboard newspaper.

a new round of blackboard newspaper creation began, we often witnessed such moments:

> In a classroom, a boy was surrounded by a group of children. They were arguing vociferously about the design of the blackboard newspaper. Gama Rinyi, a 16-year-old boy who is good at drawing Thangka (Tibetan scroll painting), is usually in charge of publishing the blackboard newspaper in this class. Gama Rinyi's classmates gathered around him, and everyone is brainstorming ideas for the design of the blackboard newspaper. A boy pointed to the blackboard and said, 'You should draw more yaks here, to have a natural appearance'. Another student said, 'Oh, yes! draw more Tibetan antelopes here'. Another student said, 'You should also draw a tent on this mountain'. A girl continued, 'All of you are too rustic and old-fashioned! It's better to draw a Doraemon (a Japanese anime character)'.
>
> Later, Gama Rinyi recalled those proud moments: 'My grandfather taught me how to draw Thangka when I was a kid. Whenever we have to publish a blackboard newspaper, my classmates always recommended that I be responsible for drawing and writing. They said they liked the Thangka I drew, and our class has won first place [of the blackboard competition] many times. I also like to write some Tibetan poems on the blackboard. I am very proud to show it on the blackboard so that more students and Han teachers can get closer to our culture.'

In addition to catching sight of some popular or personality elements existing in youth culture or subculture (such as video games, celebrities, buzzwords), the blackboard newspaper in TsuGur contains many religious and emotional elements. No matter which class one enters, the blackboard newspaper is visibly peppered with symbols of Tibetan ethnic culture (see Figure 2). The edge of the blackboard is often decorated with unique patterns, which have a positive meaning of happiness or good luck in Tibetan Buddhist

Figure 2. Symbols of Tibetan ethnic culture on the blackboard newspaper.

culture (also see Figure 1). These ethnic symbols and scriptures have nothing to do with the theme of the blackboard newspaper. However, students tend to add them because they think it represents their identity.

Elements such as local animals (yaks, tercel, etc.), landmarks (temple, snow mountain), natural scenery (blue sky and white clouds), or cultural symbols (snow lotus) are familiar tropes. They can be seen everywhere on the blackboard of each class. Students' nostalgia for their hometowns and families often appears as well. Laktseyi, a girl in eighth grade, longed for her turn to design the blackboard newspaper:

> I am very happy when it's my turn to publish the blackboard newspaper because I can draw whatever I want … I want to draw patterns related to my hometown and family, such as Tibetan antelope, yak, and other animals that live on the grassland. Because it would make me feel very warm and we [her classmates] all thought Tibetan patterns are good-looking.

As a result, students appropriated the blackboard newspaper publication for their own emotional and esthetic expressions. Teachers and administrators drew a line above certain religious, political themes or words but did not bother to censor everything created by the students. Through our conversations, they often expressed pride in their students. In a seemingly rigid school, the blackboard newspaper offered students new social spaces that mixed official tasks with their own creations. The blackboard newspaper, as a tiny space away from academic learning, alleviated students' disenchantment to some extent.

Physical and artistic activities

Other than the appropriation of designated school activities, students actively embraced non-learning activities as well. The school offers a variety of extracurriculars, most notably sports and artistic activities. When we first walked into the school, the sporty atmosphere surprised us. In a typical academic-leaning Chinese school, there is only a small proportion of students who play sports. TsuGur's schoolyard and its football field, on the contrary, were always full of students. Boys and girls scrambled to find a place for their favorite sport once a class finished. We noticed many girls were playing football and basketball, which is quite rare in other schools (see Figure 3). Even during the short ten-minute intermission between classes, students would flock to the playground and seem eager to display their athletic talents.

TsuGur students excelled in various physical competitions and are especially good at football, track and field, archery, and basketball. The teachers all believed that the students were inherently good at and accustomed to playing sports. Endowed with physical prowess, students displayed far more confidence and enthusiasm in athletic activities than we observed them to have in academic learning. Luo Dolga, the director of the senior students, jokingly told us, 'Our students are all soldiers. They are soldiers not for learning, of course, they are soldiers of sports'. Ga Dronpa, a 14-year-old boy on the school's football team, shared his opinion of the students' fiery football passion:

> We grew up running around on the grassland. There is nothing interesting to do in our pasture, and I could only play football and basketball with my friends in my leisure

Figure 3. Girls playing football.

> time in the old days. Our Tibetans have better physical strength than many other opponents so that they can hardly win. I love playing football. Running on the playground makes me feel good, especially when I score a goal. Of course, I can't find this nice feeling in my study.

Sandi Tsomo, a 16-year-old girl, sitting next to him, continued:

> Sports mean a lot to us, and I think my world has become wonderful because of them. Many girls in our school also like to play football and basketball. Because we are not so good at (academic) learning, the school supports the development of our sporting talents. We feel that playing football can give us a sense of freedom.

Similar to sports, TsuGur students also excelled at artistic activities. Students and teachers often reiterated a common saying to us that Tibetan people dance when they start walking and sing when they start talking. Dancing and singing elements were mainstays among Tibetan communities, appearing at local festivals, religious ceremonies, weddings, and harvest celebrations. In TsuGur, a variety of artistic activities fascinated students. Compared with other activities (such as Chinese calligraphy, debating team, and knowledge quiz), art activities attracted more adolescents (see Figure 4). Genka Tashi, a 15-year-old boy who performs Lhamo, the Tibetan opera, expressed his inclination:

> My father is a Tibetan Opera performer. When I was very young, many boys in my hometown would learn Lhamo performance. I like dancing and singing Lhamo very much. Everyone says that I have an incredible singing voice. Whenever school holds art activities, my classmates are all very excited and we will spontaneously organize rehearsal programs. We are all good at dancing and singing.

Figure 4. Students dancing and singing in Tibetan costumes.

In both cases, students were more willing and more active with these nonacademic activities offered by the school than they were with the regular academic course-load. Compared with other academic-oriented secondary schools, the proportion of recreational activities in TsuGur seems much higher. For instance, there are biweekly student performances at different scales; some events are held on the playground, others in the school's indoor stadium. The year-long sports tournament was also highly visible. For school administrators, the inclusion of sports and arts into school curricula partly reflected a realization that despite the official policy, their students are unlikely to succeed on the traditional academic path. While disenchanted by classroom experiences, students quickly shifted their attention and energy toward aspects that were more appealing, comfortable, and less controlled. A budding local youth culture emerged in a rigid academic setting. Students dressed up the unstimulating environment with elements that interested them. The achievements in recreational activities also make up for their disenchantment with classroom learning.

The performance of local Tibetan youth culture inside the TsuGur

In the case of blackboard newspapers, students appropriated the formal parts of school life to express themselves without violating the formal norms. Students' interpretations of beauty, religion, friendship, popular youth culture, and personal sentiments are all visible elements of the blackboard newspapers. Their appropriation did not go entirely unnoticed.

The school administrators view the newspaper as a display of state ideology with a unique ethnic character. But the boundary is more subtle than we initially thought. For instance, teachers forbade religious elements to appear in the newspaper, but what about an unexplicit quote from the scriptures? A drawing of the sacred animals (Figure 2)? The use of stylized calligraphy (Figure 1)? To be sure, there is unmistakable censorship and evident disciplining of the students. But the students did not simply hold back. Yeshe Gentso, an 18-year-old senior, described to us the form his resistance took:

> Once a school teacher said that we should not draw too many Tibetan patterns on it. However, the more he doesn't let us draw our own patterns, the more we have to draw. Because I don't think we can abandon our culture.

The back-and-forth nature of the teacher-student relationship represents a series of Goffmanian interactions. Students sometimes openly pushed back against teachers' decisions as well as negotiated the design of each publication. We observed that teachers called out several newspapers when the students put too many Tibetan words or drew too many religious patterns. But the interpretation of 'too many' is subjective, and more often than not, the teachers allowed the images.

It is natural then to meditate on the role of the school. Were they simply foisting an academic culture onto the students? In a way, yes, as reflected in the school schedules where academic classes took up major segments of the day. However, many educators had their own doubts. Damba Gyatso, the vice-principal, told us:

> The school also knows that it is difficult for most of them [the students] to have a good way out through academic learning … We hope they can find another way out for themselves.

Figure 5. Tug-of-war competition at noon every day.

Therefore, intentionally or not, these spaces outside of academic learning buffered the dreadful classes for many students. In some cases, they even led students toward a new direction. By the end of our study, the school had set up an atelier with professional art teachers. In the process of blackboard newspaper production, students with art talent (drawing and painting) would be selected to begin preparation for art schools. Similarly, the school held many kinds of sports activities to enrich students' school life. We observed a tug-of-war competition at noon every day (see Figure 5), and every month an interclass football tournament would be held. We witnessed wave after wave of students rehearsing for their upcoming artistic activities in the rehearsal hall throughout the whole semester.

Conclusions

Schooling is one of the most consequential social processes for the youth. As scholars, we would like to explicitly acknowledge the alienation and marginalization that happened in the school we studied. The academically oriented curriculum, strict language policy, and epistemological disparities did disenchant many young minds. Yet, if the change is constant and ongoing, what became of the disenchanted youth? The teenagers of our study just embarked on their lives. Our year-long observations and interviews indicated that change brings bewilderment inside the classroom and simultaneously leads students toward other social spaces. In TsuGur, students were like air in a closed container. Pushed from one side, kinetics leads the air molecules to move toward other directions, eventually filling up all empty parts of the closed container—the school's social space. The

students we observed quickly shifted their attention and energy toward more appealing subjects. Students decoded the school rules by performing an observant student persona inside the classroom. Yet their true passion shined outside of (or rather, after) formal classes concluded.

Existing literature clearly shows that disenchantment is very common among rural, migrant, and ethnic minority students (Hannum, 2003; Postiglione, 2008; Wu, 2012). However, the existing studies have tended to view disenchantment as a fixed state. What eventually became of the disenchanted youth? This study provides additional views on these questions.

We agreed with Abbott (2016) that change is the norm in social life. When viewing disenchantment from a processual point of view, it is natural to seek how the disenchantment plays out in social space and social time. Students appropriated the routine task of creating blackboard newspapers. They slipped in content that speaks to their religious and ethnic beliefs despite knowing that their expression of religiosity and ethnic identity is not officially encouraged. Their passion for sports and art events far exceeded their other high school counterparts. Fighting among the students was common, especially among the boys. Their fights can be interpreted as displays of masculinity, a sense of ethnic pride, and unintimidated raw energy. In several cases, they were stereotyped, challenged, or disciplined, particularly by Han teachers, but more often than not, they were sympathized with, acquiesced to, and even encouraged in some instances by teachers and administrators.

It is in this sense that this study provides new insights into the studies of disenchanted youth. Globally, studies tend to view academic schools as places rife with tension (Leibold & Grose, 2019; Wu, 2012). We argue that some school space is actually porous and elastic. Beyond the seeming rigidity of time arrangement and of classroom and behavioral norms, there also existed spaces that were relatively free or spontaneous.

In several cases, it was boredom and disconnectedness that directed students' attention and energy toward these spaces. Did they eventually discover other paths toward life? We believe so, as few would eventually go to college, and most would find a job in nearby cities or go back to their family ranches. Our research is limited to one academic year; therefore, we could not garner much information about students' future trajectories. But to say the future is to understand the present. TsuGur students' ethnic identity and religious inclination are by no means tarnished. Instead, many came to the realization that the prescribed academic road leads to nowhere. Indeed, their lives carried on (some to universities or vocational schools), sometimes with muted voices. Though to define their actions as passive or indifferent would be a prejudiced mistake.

Beyond the Chinese setting, this study provides a lesson to educators who work with minority youth in many developing countries. TsuGur is a well-managed school and the educators there care for their students. But educators in TsuGur have yet to embrace more progressive ideas such as culturally responsive pedagogy (Gay, 2002, 2015). We believe that bringing cultural relevance inside the school could make a difference. Thus we call for greater attention to such alternatives. Today, rural/ethnic students in many countries do face a similar dilemma. Their schooling experiences deserve researchers' further attention.

Notes

1. Readers of the early drafts of this paper reported confusion over the term 'outcome-at-a-point view vis-à-vis processual view'. We believe this is because the discussion of changes over life courses is strangely missing from many empirical investigations of school life. But researchers from diverse traditions have all highlighted such an issue. See Abbott (2016) Chapters 6 and 7 for a general treatment. The focus on the spatial-temporal dimension is a characteristic of processual analysis. We intentionally overdraw the distinction here to raise awareness.
2. This debate certainly demonstrates a fractal quality, identifiable as it is across the social science disciplines. In sociology, such a distinction centers on the importance of time and location (Abbott, 1997). In anthropology, the extended case methods proponents and the structuralists also argued over such a distinction. In economics, those who hold a discounting view of human behavior differ from their neoclassic contemporaries (Ainslie, 1992). Our position here is based on the acknowledgement of different layers of temporality. But the task is to explain social change when our colleagues deliberately conceive the world as instantaneous.
3. *neidiban* refers to the 'interior minority boarding class' (Leibold & Grose, 2019). It is a type of relocation boarding school project populated by recruiting ethnic minority students to receive better secondary education in China's eastern developed cities. Students who enrolled in the *neidiban* are normally Tibetan and Uyghur teenagers because educators believe that both geographic remoteness and low economic development pose serious educational challenges for them (Yang, 2019).
4. CMI is a teaching mode designed for promoting Mandarin Chinese (*putonghua*) among ethnic minority students in China. It requires that all subjects in ethnic primary and secondary schools be taught in Mandarin Chinese. On the one hand, CMI mode affords ethnic students extra access to better education as well as help integrating into mainstream Chinese society (Zhang & Pérez-Milans, 2019); on the other hand, it has been criticized for impairing ethnic minorities' language and culture (Gao & Ren, 2019).

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ORCID

Liqin Tong http://orcid.org/0000-0001-8945-6108
Yisu Zhou http://orcid.org/0000-0001-9246-9700

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